DESIGN THINKING

Designing Your Work Life

How to Thrive and Change and Find Happiness at Work

Bill Burnett and Dave Evans · 2020

The authors of *Designing Your Life* bring design thinking to the job you already have, so you can make it better before deciding whether to leave. Reissued in 2021 as *Designing Your New Work Life*.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- Practical exercises for anyone who feels stuck at work[3,4]
- A humane take on money, meaning, burnout and office politics[5]
- Smart advice on how to quit well, if you do decide to go[6,8]



GET THE BOOK

Designing Your Work Life by Bill Burnett and Dave Evans
Alfred A. Knopf, 2020. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *Designing Your Work Life* by Bill Burnett and Dave Evans. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Redesign before you resign

Most people assume the only fix for a frustrating job is a new one. Burnett and Evans argue that you can almost always make your current job work better first, by reframing stuck beliefs, running small experiments and treating "good enough for now" as a base to build on.[1,4,5]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Reframe stuck beliefs**
   Every chapter starts with a dysfunctional belief and a reframe. Feeling like a cog in a machine becomes being a lever that can move it.[4]

2. **Good enough for now**
   Not forever, just for now. Accepting that gives you a stable base to improve from, instead of waiting to arrive.[4]

3. **Overwhelm isn't burnout**
   Overwhelm can be designed around. True burnout or a toxic workplace may be a reason to leave.[5,7]

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THE FRAMEWORK

Don't Resign, Redesign[3,7]

Four options to try, smallest first, before deciding to quit.[7]

1 Reframe and re-enlist

A new why for the same job

Find a fresh reason the work matters to you.[7]

Try: Write down what this job gives you that you'd miss.

2 Remodel

Change the role

Cosmetic or structural changes to what you do.[7]

Try: Trade one task you dread for one you'd enjoy.

3 Relocate

Move within the company

Find a different role where you are.[7]

Try: Have coffee with a team you admire.

4 Reinvent

Retrain inside

Build new skills toward a new career without leaving.[7]

Try: Take on a stretch project.

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

The Good Work Journal

This book's version of the Good Time Journal.[4]

1. Each day, note what you learned, what you initiated, and who you helped.
2. Keep it going for three to four weeks.
3. Each week, look for surprises and which category dominates.
4. Plan one way to grow the missing category.

The Maker's Mix

Instead of money versus meaning, rate three kinds of making.[3,5]

1. Score money-making, impact-making and expression-making from 1 to 100.
2. Set your ideal mix, like faders on a mixing desk.
3. Close the biggest gap with a small prototype, inside or outside work.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Write your most stuck belief about work, then reframe it.
2. Score your Maker's Mix.
3. Choose one of the four redesign options to try.
4. Start a Good Work Journal tonight.

REFLECT

If your job were good enough for now, what would you build on first?

Which kind of making is missing from your work?

Try it in Sedi: Turn your reframe into a project in Timely's Planning view, with the first prototype as its first task.

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Bill Burnett and Dave Evans · Alfred A. Knopf · 2020

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Bill Burnett and Dave Evans or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

1. Burnett, Bill, and Dave Evans. *Designing Your Work Life*. Alfred A. Knopf, 2020. Ch. "Money or meaning", "My overwhelm is overwhelmed", "Don't resign, redesign!", "Quitting well".
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